Your Complete Small Business Launch Checklist

Starting your own business is an exciting journey that requires careful planning and execution. This comprehensive guide walks you through every essential step—from choosing your business structure to landing your first clients. Whether you're launching a bookkeeping practice or another service-based business, these foundational steps will set you up for success. Follow this roadmap to transform your entrepreneurial vision into reality, one actionable step at a time.

Foundation: Legal & Administrative Setup

Building a solid legal foundation protects both you and your business. Start by choosing a memorable business name that reflects your brand identity. Consider forming an LLC (Limited Liability Company) to shield your personal assets from business liabilities—it's the sweet spot between simplicity and protection for most solo entrepreneurs.

01

Choose Your Business Name

Select a memorable, professional name that reflects your services and resonates with your target market.

02

Select Business Structure

LLCs offer liability protection with simpler compliance than corporations—ideal for solo entrepreneurs and small teams.

03

File Articles of Organization

Register your LLC with your state's Secretary of State office. Costs vary by state, typically $50-200. Visit **your state's business registration portal** for specific requirements.

04

Obtain Necessary Licenses

Research city, county, and state licensing requirements. Requirements vary significantly by location and industry—check your local government websites early in the process.

05

Get Your EIN

Apply for an **Employer Identification Number** through the IRS. This free process takes minutes online and you'll need it for taxes and banking.

Financial Infrastructure

Clean financial practices start from day one. Separating personal and business finances isn't just good practice—it simplifies bookkeeping, protects your liability shield, and makes tax time dramatically easier.

Open Business Bank Account

Establish dedicated checking and savings accounts for your business. Run *all* business transactions through these

Secure Business Insurance

Protect your venture with Errors and Omissions (E&O) insurance, also called professional liability insurance. This coverage

Set Up Accounting Software

Choose reliable accounting software like QuickBooks Online, Xero, or FreshBooks. QuickBooks Online is industry-standard